

30 days with HP Chromebook 15

Jayesh Shinde | jayesh @digit.in

When HP decided to send their newest Chromebook for review, I decided to make it my primary work-n-play laptop for a month to see if I could completely work out of a web browser.

For starters, the HP Chromebook 15a-na0012TU is a perfectly dependable laptop, with a 15.6-inch matte screen, full keyboard with dedicated number pad, and a large palmrest with a wide trackpad in the centre. There's nothing to not love about the HP Chromebook 15 in terms of build and design, as it looks and feels like a modern, full-fledged Windows laptop. It's well-built, weighs 1.1 kg and doesn't feel cheap, despite its low asking price.

The HP Chromebook has 4GB of RAM, 128GB of eMMC storage, and Intel Celeron N4500 with a max speed of 2.80GHz. This may not sound a whole lot but it's more than enough for ChromeOS, the HP Chromebook's operating system that feels a lot like a stripped down version of Windows or macOS. It has a stripped down file explorer, task bar with an app launcher, and system icons along the bottom screen bezel – familiar elements from Windows or Mac. Icons of several Google apps like Files, YouTube, Photos, Calendar, Gmail, Meet and Play, including Chrome, are visible prominently to launch quickly. Almost everything on the HP Chromebook 15 happens inside the Chrome browser, which is the main focus of the user experience.

Who doesn't get everything done out of their Google Chrome browser these days? Unless you're a graphics designer, animator, gamer, niche programmer or work in finance, chances are most of what you do online on your laptop is done through Google Chrome. That

includes me. Apart from working on Adobe PhotoShop or InDesign (used for Digit Magazine), everything else was easily managed within Chrome: from writing articles on Google Docs, responding to work email through Gmail, editing presentations on Slides, analysing survey data through Sheets, and much more. Thanks to Google's Play Store and Chrome's Web Store integration, you can access almost all Android apps and Chrome plugins without skipping a beat.

On most days I would have several tabs open on Chrome (including Gmail, Docs, Sheets), work on Google Docs while listening to Spotify in the background, launch YouTube to take a quick video break in between, attend work calls on Google Meet, and chat with



people on WhatsApp.

Switching between Chrome to any other app like Spotify or WhatsApp in the background was super intuitive with a three-finger swipe up on the HP Chromebook's large trackpad. I could download compressed zip files, uncompress them and extract data. Pen drives and wired mouse plugged into the HP Chromebook's solitary USB-A worked just fine, so did Bluetooth or wired headphones – no problems whatsoever. Additionally, HP QuickDrop lets you pair the Chromebook to an Android or iOS device to transfer data between devices over Bluetooth, which works as advertised – photos, documents and

messages were easily sent from my paired phone to the Chromebook.

The HP Chromebook easily lasts over 8 hours of use on a single charge, and without too much multimedia in the background it regularly chugged past 10 hours before I had to plug back in, which is very good battery life. The only time I had the Chromebook struggling is when I had 15 tabs running on Chrome, with YouTube and Spotify apps playing simultaneously, and I started Real Racing 3 to play a quick game – but most people won't be doing this, so it's all good. Despite breaking a sweat, Alt + Escape worked, so did pushing the mouse to the top-right of any full-screened resource hungry app, which you can immediately minimise.

Unlike Windows, the Chromebook didn't throw any BSOD! Despite everything that went well, there are a few areas of improvement on the HP Chromebook – the keyboard's arrow keys are too tiny, and its matte screen and 1366x768 resolution isn't great for watching videos. The audio from the laptop's down firing speakers isn't very loud either, but a 3.5-mm headphone jack fixes that. A few apps from Google Play open in tablet mode, so they aren't customised for ChromeOS. I can imagine why the matte screen and low audio works by design for a student user of the Chromebook. These aren't flaws but features to help young minds who use the Chromebook reduce their distraction levels and pay more attention to academics on their screen. Point well taken.

In summary, should you buy a Chromebook? Depends on who you are and what you're going to do on your Chromebook. If you're a student, working professional or elderly user who largely works out of their Google Chrome browser, think of it as an Android tablet without the touchscreen and all the familiarity of a laptop computer. It's a good big-screen-but-lightweight laptop purchase at ₹30,000, especially for a student. Will I continue to use it for another 30 days? You bet! 